



INSIGHTSIAS
SIMPLIFYING IAS EXAM PREPARATION

MAPPINGS FOR UPSC CSE: IMPORTANT PLACES IN NEWS IN INDIA & THE WORLD



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MAPPING WORLD:

IRAN



- **Iran** (officially the Islamic Republic of Iran) is a major West Asian country with a long civilizational history dating back to the ancient Persian Empire.
- Since the [1979 Islamic Revolution](#), it has functioned as an Islamic republic combining republican institutions with clerical authority, where the Supreme Leader holds ultimate power.

Location:

- Located in **Southwestern Asia (West Asia / Middle East)**.
- Strategically positioned between Central Asia, South Asia, and the Middle East, overlooking key maritime routes in the [Persian Gulf](#).
- **Capital:** Tehran
- **Bordering Nations:**
- Azerbaijan, Armenia, Turkmenistan, Afghanistan, Pakistan, Turkey, and Iraq.

It also has coastlines along:

- Caspian Sea, Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman.

Key Features:

- Dominated by a **central arid plateau** surrounded by mountain ranges.
- **Zagros Mountains:** Stretch northwest–southeast; major barrier and resource region.
- **Alborz Mountains:** Located near the Caspian Sea; includes **Mount Damavand**, Iran's highest peak.
- **Large deserts:** Dasht-e Kavir and Dasht-e Lut.
- Highly **seismic region** with frequent earthquakes due to tectonic activity.
- Important water bodies include [Lake Urmia](#) and rivers like **Karun** and **Sefid**.

Significance:

- Controls access near the Strait of Hormuz, through which a major share of global oil trade passes.
- Possesses vast reserves of oil and natural gas, influencing global energy markets.

THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ



- The **Strait of Hormuz** is a narrow but strategically vital waterway that serves as the primary maritime passage for oil and gas exports from the Persian Gulf to global markets.

Location:

- Lies between **Iran** (north) and **Oman** (south).
- Connects the [Persian Gulf](#) to the **Gulf of Oman** and the **Arabian Sea**, opening into the wider Indian Ocean.
- At its narrowest point, it is about **33 km wide**, with shipping lanes only about **3 km wide in each direction**.

Key Features:

- **Major Energy Corridor:** About **20% of global oil supply** (over 20 million barrels per day) transits this route.
- **LNG Hub:** Nearly all of **Qatar's LNG exports** pass through the strait.
- **Global Chokepoint:** Second-busiest oil transit chokepoint after the Strait of Malacca.
- **Limited Alternatives:** While Saudi Arabia and the UAE have partial pipeline bypass options, most Gulf exports depend on this route.
- **International Waterway:** Though within Iranian and Omani territorial waters, it is open to global navigation under international maritime law.

Significance

- Any disruption directly impacts oil and gas prices worldwide, affecting inflation and economic stability.
- Presence of the **U.S. Fifth Fleet** in [Bahrain](#) underscores its geopolitical value.

LEBANON



- **Lebanon** is a small sovereign country in the Middle East located on the eastern shore of the Mediterranean Sea.
- It has historically served as a **commercial and cultural crossroads** between the Arab world, Europe, and Asia.

Location:

- Lebanon lies in the **Levant region** of **West Asia** along the eastern Mediterranean coast.

Capital: The capital city of Lebanon is **Beirut**.

Neighbouring countries: Lebanon shares borders with:

- Syria, Israel, and Mediterranean Sea

Features:

Lebanon has diverse mountainous terrain and four major physiographic regions:

- **Coastal Plain** – A narrow fertile strip along the Mediterranean coast containing major cities like Beirut and Sidon.
- **Lebanon Mountains (Mount Lebanon Range)** – A prominent limestone mountain chain running parallel to the coast, famous for the **Cedars of Lebanon** forests.
- **Bekaa Valley** – A fertile agricultural valley between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon mountain ranges; it forms part of the **Great Rift Valley system**.
- **Anti-Lebanon Mountains and Mount Hermon** – Eastern mountain chain forming a natural border with Syria.
- Highly **mountainous terrain**, making internal travel difficult.
- One of the most densely populated Mediterranean countries.

FINLAND



- Finland is a Nordic country in Northern Europe, known for its strong welfare system, advanced technology sector, and high **environmental standards**.
- It gained independence from Russia on 6 December 1917 after being part of Sweden and later the Russian Empire.
- **Capital:** Helsinki

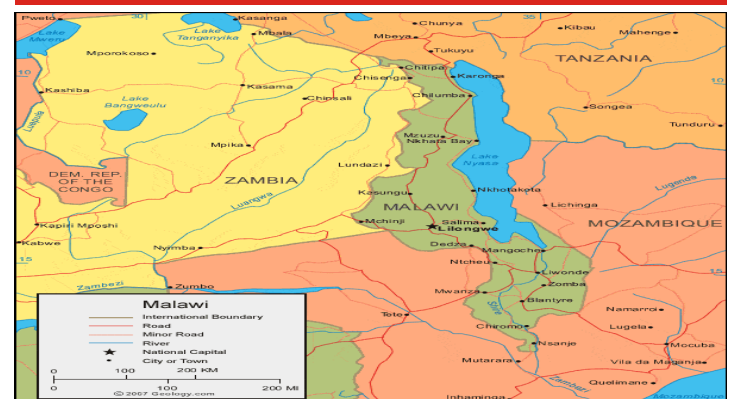
Neighbouring Nations:

- Norway, Russia, and Sweden.
- Surrounded by water bodies such as the **Gulf of Finland** and **Gulf of Bothnia**.

Key Features:

- **Highly Forested Landscape** – Nearly two-thirds of Finland is covered by forests, making it one of the most densely forested countries in Europe.
- **Land of Lakes** – Finland has about 56,000 lakes, with Lake Saimaa being the largest.
- **Precambrian Shield** – The country sits on an ancient granite shield formed during Precambrian geological periods.
- **Glacial Landforms** – Landscapes shaped by Ice Age glaciation, producing features like moraines and eskers (gravel ridges).
- **Arctic Geography** – Around one-third of Finland lies north of the **Arctic Circle**, experiencing phenomena such as the midnight sun and polar night.

MALAWI



- Malawi is a landlocked country in southeastern Africa known for its agriculture-based economy and large [freshwater lake system](#).
- The country is heavily dependent on subsistence farming, making it vulnerable to climate shocks such as droughts and floods.
- **Location:** Malawi is located in **southeastern Africa** along the East African Rift Valley.
- **Capital City:** Lilongwe
- **Neighbouring Nations:** Tanzania, Mozambique, and Zambia.

Key Geographical Features

- **East African Rift Valley** – The country lies along the [Great Rift Valley](#), shaping much of its topography.
- **Lake Malawi (Lake Nyasa)** – One of Africa's largest lakes, covering over one-fifth of Malawi's total area and forming part of its eastern boundary.
- **Shire River Valley** – The **Shire River**, the only outlet of Lake Malawi, flows southward into the **Zambezi River**.
- **Highlands and Plateaus** – Includes regions such as the Nyika Highlands and Shire Highlands, with elevations above 2,000 metres.
- **Mulanje Mountain Massif** – The **highest point in Malawi (3,002 m)** located in southeastern Malawi.
- **Lake Chilwa Basin** – A shallow inland lake system important for local fisheries and wetlands.

THE GULF NATIONS



- Gulf nations primarily refers to the six sovereign states that form the **Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC)**. Established in 1981, this political and economic union was created to foster regional integration and collective security among the Arab states bordering the Persian Gulf.

Member States:

- The GCC consists of six monarchies:
 1. United Arab Emirates (UAE)
 2. Kingdom of Bahrain
 3. Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
 4. [Sultanate of Oman](#)
 5. State of Qatar
 6. State of Kuwait

Key Geographical and Geological Features:

1. **The Arabian Shield:** A vast Precambrian complex of igneous and metamorphic rocks in the west, which provides a stable foundation for the sedimentary layers in the east where oil is found.
2. **Persian Gulf Lowlands:** The eastern part of the peninsula slopes gently toward the shallow Persian Gulf, creating an ideal environment for offshore oil and gas drilling.
3. **Rub' al Khali (The Empty Quarter):** The largest continuous sand desert in the world, covering much of southern Saudi Arabia and parts of Oman and the UAE. It sits atop ancient lake beds rich in fossil fuels.
4. **Strategic Chokepoints:** The region is defined by the [Strait of Hormuz](#), a narrow waterway through which approximately **20% of global oil** and **20% of LNG** shipments transit daily.
5. **Arid Climate and Wadis:** Characterized by extreme heat (often exceeding 50°C) and a landscape of plateaus and wadis (intermittent river valleys) that are dry for most of the year.

CHILE ELIMINATE LEPROSY

The World Health Organization ([WHO](#)) and the Pan American Health Organization (PAHO) officially verified Chile as the first country in the Americas—and the second globally—to have eliminated leprosy.



About Leprosy (Hansen's Disease):

- Leprosy is a chronic infectious disease caused by the slow-growing bacterium ***Mycobacterium leprae***. It primarily affects the skin, the peripheral nerves, mucosal surfaces of the upper respiratory tract, and the eyes. If left untreated, it can cause progressive and permanent damage to the skin, nerves, limbs, and eyes.

Origin and History:

- **Ancient Disease:** Leprosy is one of the oldest recorded diseases in human history, mentioned in ancient civilizations' texts from China, Egypt, and India.

- **Chilean Context:** It was historically recorded in Chile at the end of the 19th century, specifically on **Rapa Nui (Easter Island)**. It remained localized there through strict isolation and treatment until the late 1990s.

Key Features

- **Transmission:** It is transmitted via droplets from the nose and mouth during close and frequent contact with untreated cases. It is **not** highly infectious.
- **Incubation Period:** The disease has a very **long incubation period**, averaging **5 years**, though symptoms can take up to 20 years to appear.
- **Symptoms:** Pale or reddish skin patches with loss of sensation, painless ulcers on the soles of feet, and muscle weakness or tingling in the hands and feet.

Treatment

- **Multi-Drug Therapy (MDT):** Since the 1980s, WHO has provided MDT (a combination of rifampicin, dapson, and clofazimine) for free globally.
- **Curability:** Leprosy is **100% curable**. Early treatment prevents most disabilities associated with the disease.
- **Stigma:** Historically, patients were shunned or leper colonies were created. Modern public health focuses on **stigma-free, integrated care**.

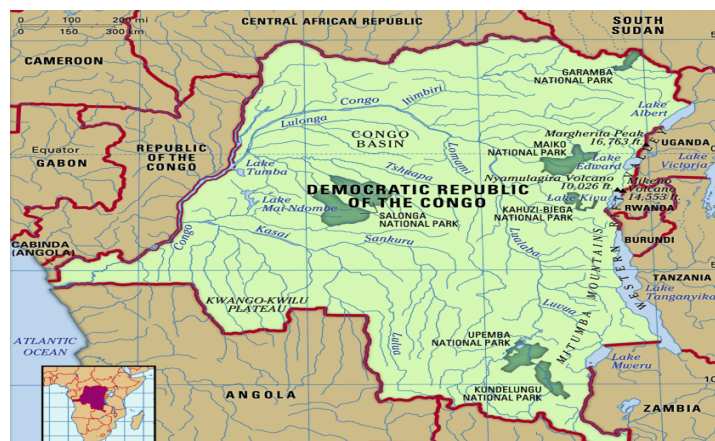
About Chile:

- Chile is a sovereign country in **western South America**, known for its extreme geographic diversity and highly developed economy (the first South American member of the OECD).
- **Geography:** It occupies a long, narrow strip of land between the **Andes Mountains** to the east and the **Pacific Ocean** to the west.
- **Borders:** Peru, Bolivia, Argentina and the Drake Passage.

Geographic Features

- **Atacama Desert:** Located in the north, it is known as the **driest non-polar place on Earth**.
- **Central Valley:** A Mediterranean-climate region that is the agricultural and population heartland of the country.
- **The South:** Characterized by **alpine tundras**, glaciers, fjords, and lakes.
- **Insular Territories:** Includes the famous **Rapa Nui (Easter Island)** in Polynesia and the Juan Fernández Archipelago.

UPEMBA NATIONAL PARK



- Upemba National Park is one of Africa's oldest national parks and an important biodiversity hotspot in the Congo Basin ecosystem.
- It was established by royal decree in May 1939 and plays a key role in protecting wildlife and freshwater ecosystems in **Central Africa**.
- **Located in:** Southeastern Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC).
- The park spans across **three provinces**:
 - Lualaba
 - Haut-Katanga
 - Haut-Lomami
- **Neighbouring Protected Areas:** The park lies close to **Kundelungu National Park**, with the **Lubudi-Sampwe** hunting reserve acting as an ecological corridor between them.

Key Features

- **Large Protected Area** – Covers around **12,752 km²**, including a core conservation zone and annex areas.
- **Unique Biogeographic Location** – Situated at the intersection of the Zambezan and Guinean biogeographic regions, resulting in high biodiversity.
- **Diverse Landscapes** – Includes savanna valleys, high plateaus with gallery forests, and the **Kamalondo Depression wetlands**.
- **Important Freshwater Ecosystem** – Contains over 80 interconnected lakes, including Lake Upemba, rich in endemic fish species.
- **Source of Major Rivers** – Hosts the headwaters of several rivers including the Lualaba River, which forms the upper course of the **Congo River**.
- **Wildlife Habitat** – Provides refuge for species such as savanna elephants, zebras, Katanga buffalo, and other endemic fauna.

DEVON ISLAND



- Devon Island is the **largest uninhabited island on Earth**. Because of its extreme cold, dry climate, and barren landscape, it is used by scientists as a terrestrial analogue for the surface of Mars.
- **Located in:** It is situated in the [Arctic Archipelago](#) within the territory of **Nunavut, Canada**. It lies well within the Arctic Circle.

Neighbouring Regions:

- **North:** Separated from Ellesmere Island by the Jones Sound.
- **South:** Separated from Somerset Island and Baffin Island by the Lancaster Sound.
- **West:** [Cornwallis Island](#) (home to the settlement of Resolute).
- **East:** Baffin Bay.

Geographic Features:

- **Haughton Impact Crater:** A massive **20-kilometre-wide** crater formed roughly 39 million years ago. Its rocky, rubbly terrain and absence of vegetation make it a near-perfect visual and physical match for Martian craters.
- **Polar Desert:** The island receives very little precipitation and remains freezing year-round, resulting in a landscape devoid of trees or surface plants.
- **Unique Terrain:** Features include permafrost, underground ice, dried-up lakebeds, and deep canyons that mimic Martian valleys.
- **Endolithic Habitats:** The rocks within the Haughton Crater house microorganisms that live inside the stone to survive extreme UV radiation, a process known as [endolithic colonisation](#).

THE SILVERPIT CRATER



- The Silverpit crater is a complex geological structure buried deep beneath the seabed. Long a subject of scientific debate, it is now confirmed as an impact crater, one of over 200 known on Earth, providing a rare look at undersea [asteroid collisions](#).

Located In:

- **Geography:** Situated approximately 80 miles (130 km) off the coast of **Yorkshire (specifically Hull)** in the United Kingdom.
- **Depth:** It lies **700 metres below the seabed** of the North Sea.

Formation:

- **The Event:** Formed roughly **43–46 million years ago** during the Eocene epoch.
- **The Cause:** A high-velocity impact of an **asteroid approximately 160 metres wide**.
- **The Aftermath:** The explosion created a 1.5-kilometre-high curtain of rock and water. Its collapse generated a 100-metre-high megatsunami.
- **Scientific Proof:** Researchers identified [shocked quartz](#) and [feldspar](#)—microscopic crystals with structural deformations that only occur under the extreme pressure of an asteroid strike.

Key Features:

- **Dimensions:** The central crater is about **3 kilometres wide**.
- **Structural Rings:** It is surrounded by a massive system of [concentric circular faults](#) (rings) spanning about **20 km** in diameter.
- **Morphology:** It features a classic central peak, a common characteristic of high-energy impact sites where the ground rebounds after being struck.

KHARG ISLAND



- Kharg Island is a small coral island that serves as Iran's primary crude oil export terminal.
- It functions as the main hub for loading and exporting Iranian oil to global markets, handling a significant portion of the country's [petroleum shipments](#).

Location:

- Located in the **northern Persian Gulf**, about **50–55 km from the Iranian mainland** and northwest of the port of **Bushehr**.
- Positioned close to deep waters, allowing very large crude carriers (VLCCs) to dock and load oil.

Geological Features:

- Kharg Island is a **five-mile-long coral island**, formed from **coral limestone deposits** in the Persian Gulf.
- Unlike many Gulf islands, it has **natural freshwater resources**, which historically supported settlement.
- Its **proximity to deep waters** makes it suitable for super-tanker docking and large-scale oil export infrastructure.

BAB EL-MANDAB STRAIT



- The **Bab el-Mandab** is a strategic maritime chokepoint and one of the world's most vital shipping lanes. It serves as the southern gateway to the Red Sea, acting as the primary link between the Indian Ocean and the **Mediterranean Sea** (via the Suez Canal).

Location:

- **Geography:** Situated between the **Horn of Africa** (Djibouti and Eritrea) to the southwest and the **Arabian Peninsula** (Yemen) to the northeast.
- **Connectivity:** It connects the **Red Sea** to the **Gulf of Aden** and the **Arabian Sea**.
- **Key Point:** The strait is split into two channels by **Perim Island**; the western channel is the primary lane for large commercial vessels.

Origin of the Name:

- In Arabic, *Bab el-Mandab* translates to **Gate of Tears**. Legend attributes the name to the many people who drowned there during an ancient earthquake that separated Asia and Africa, or to the extreme danger posed by its narrow, treacherous navigation channels.

Key Features:

- **Width:** At its narrowest point, the strait is only about **29 kilometers (18 miles)** wide, making it

highly vulnerable to land-based missile attacks and naval blockades.

- **Volume:** It accounts for approximately **10% to 12% of global seaborne oil** and natural gas shipments.
- **Capacity:** Over **30 million tonnes of LNG** and millions of barrels of oil pass through it annually.
- **Alternative Route:** If blocked, ships must divert around the **Cape of Good Hope** (South Africa), adding roughly **4,000 to 6,000 nautical miles** and **14 to 20 days** to the journey.

CUBA



- Cuba is a socialist island nation in the Caribbean region and the largest island in the Greater Antilles of the West Indies.
- It is politically organised as a unitary socialist republic with its capital at Havana.

Located in:

- Cuba lies at the **intersection of the Atlantic Ocean, the Gulf of Mexico, and the Caribbean Sea**, just south of the **Tropic of Cancer**.
- The country consists of around 1,600 islands, islets, and cays, forming an important part of the **Antilles island chain**.

Key Geological Features:

- **Mountain Ranges:** The Sierra Maestra is the most rugged range and contains Turquino Peak (1,974 m), the highest point in Cuba.
- **Plains and Agricultural Lands:** About two-thirds of the island consists of plains, widely used for sugarcane and tobacco cultivation.
- **Unique Karst Landscapes:** Central-western Cuba has **limestone hill formations known as mogotes**, covered with vegetation.
- **Wetlands and Swamps:** The **Zapata Peninsula** contains extensive swamps including the **Zapata Swamp**, one of the largest wetlands in the Caribbean.
- **Extensive Coastline:** Cuba has around **5,745 km of coastline** with bays, coral reefs, mangrove swamps, and cliffs.

PORT OF FUJAIRAH



- A major deep-water, multipurpose port and global oil storage/bunkering hub serving as a critical export outlet for [UAE's hydrocarbons](#).
- **Located in:** Fujairah Emirate, [United Arab Emirates](#) (UAE) on the eastern coast.

Sea Open to:

- Directly opens into the **Gulf of Oman / Arabian Sea**, bypassing the Strait of Hormuz.

Key Features:

- **Strategic Bypass Route:** Linked to Abu Dhabi via [ADCOP pipeline](#), enabling crude export without passing through Hormuz.
- **Massive Storage Capacity:** Oil storage expanded from 0.55 million cbm (1994) to ~18 million cbm.
- **Bunkering Hub:** Among the top 3 global bunkering hubs, serving international shipping.
- **Advanced Infrastructure:** Over 9.5 km quay length, modern terminals for crude, refined products, and container cargo.
- **High Maritime Activity:** Around 12,000 vessels annually; ~174 anchorage positions.
- **Integrated Industrial Zone:** Hosts **Fujairah Oil Industrial Zone (FOIZ)** and multiple global oil companies.

SPAIN



- Spain is a sovereign country located in Southwestern Europe with pockets of territory in Africa (Ceuta and Melilla). It is a parliamentary constitutional monarchy and a prominent member of the [European Union](#) (EU) and NATO.
- **Capital:** Madrid

Bordering Countries:

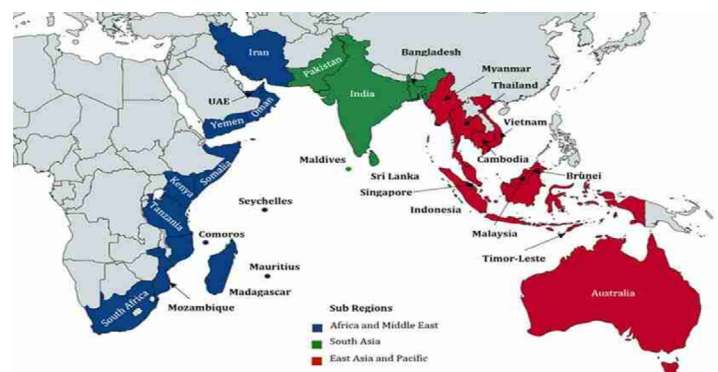
Spain occupies about 85% of the Iberian Peninsula and shares borders with five entities:

- **Portugal:** To the west.
- **France:** To the northeast, separated by the Pyrenees mountains.
- **Andorra:** A microstate nestled in the Pyrenees between Spain and France.
- **Gibraltar:** A [British Overseas Territory](#) at the southern tip.
- **Morocco:** Via the autonomous cities of Ceuta and Melilla on the North African coast.

Key Geographical Features:

- **The Meseta Central:** A vast, elevated plateau at the heart of the country, surrounded by mountain ranges.
- **The Pyrenees:** A massive mountain chain forming a natural border with France, stretching from the Bay of Biscay to the [Mediterranean](#).
- **Major Rivers:** Including the **Tagus** (longest), the **Ebro** (most voluminous in Spain), and the **Guadalquivir**.
- **Coastlines:** Spain is unique for having extensive coastlines along both the **Atlantic Ocean** to the north/west and the **Mediterranean Sea** to the south/east.
- **Archipelagos:** Includes the [Balearic Islands](#) in the Mediterranean and the volcanic **Canary Islands** in the Atlantic.

INDIAN OCEAN REGION



- The **Indian Ocean Region** refers to the vast maritime area surrounding the Indian Ocean, encompassing [coastal states](#), island nations, and major sea routes connecting Asia, Africa, and Australia.

Location:

- Lies between:
 - Asia (North)
 - Africa (West)
 - Australia (East)
 - Southern Ocean (South)
- It is the **third-largest ocean** in the world

Bordering Nations:

- It is bordered by **36 littoral nations** (including India, South Africa, Australia, Indonesia, and Saudi Arabia) and impacts 14 landlocked countries.

Key Features

1. **Strategic Choke Points:** It contains critical waterways including the **Strait of Hormuz**, the **Strait of Malacca**, the **Bab-el-Mandeb**, and the **Suez Canal**, which are vital for global energy and trade flows.
2. **Monsoon System:** It is the only ocean with an asymmetric and semi-annually reversing surface circulation driven by the monsoon winds.
3. **Abundant Resources:** The region holds massive offshore oil and natural gas reserves, particularly in the **Persian Gulf**, and accounts for a significant portion of the world's fishing catch.
4. **Island Chains:** It hosts strategically important island nations and territories such as the **Maldives**, **Mauritius**, **Seychelles**, **Comoros**, and **Madagascar**.
5. **Diverse Ecosystems:** It contains nearly 25% of the world's coral reefs and extensive mangrove forests, making it a critical zone for marine biodiversity.

RAS LAFFAN AND SOUTH PARS



- Ras Laffan is the world's largest Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) export hub, housing major liquefaction plants and export terminals.
- **Located in:** Northeastern Qatar, along the **Persian Gulf coast**

Origin:

- Ras in Arabic means headland or cape, indicating its coastal geographic position
- Developed as a strategic **LNG export** hub by QatarEnergy

Key Features:

- **Global LNG hub:** Accounts for nearly **20% of global LNG supply**.
- **Integrated infrastructure:** Houses liquefaction plants, storage tanks, export terminals.
- **QatarEnergy base:** Core operational center for Qatar's LNG exports.
- **High export capacity:** Over 77–80 million tonnes per annum LNG production.

Importance:

- Critical supplier of LNG to countries like **India**, **Japan**, **Europe**.
- Key node in **global gas supply chains**.
- Supplies **~40% of India's LNG imports**.

About South Pars Gas Field:

- The **world's largest natural gas field**, shared between Iran (South Pars) and Qatar (North Field).

Located in:

- Beneath the **Persian Gulf**, shared by:
 - Iran (South Pars)
 - Qatar (North Field)

Origin:

- South Pars refers to the southern portion of the larger gas reservoir located in Iranian territory
- Pars is derived from **Persia** (ancient Iran)

Key Features:

1. **Largest gas reserve:** Holds **one of the world's biggest proven natural gas reserves**.
2. **Shared resource:** Divided between Iran (South Pars) and Qatar (North Field).
3. **Offshore extraction:** Consists of multiple offshore platforms and processing units.
4. **Energy backbone:** Central to Qatar's **LNG dominance** and Iran's gas economy.

AIRPORTS IN NEWS



Navi Mumbai International Airport (DB Patil Airport):

- A major greenfield **international airport** developed to reduce congestion at Mumbai's existing airport.

- **Location:** Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra
- **Type:** Greenfield Airport
- **Features:**
 - Designed to decongest Mumbai airport and handle growing passenger traffic.
 - Strategic infrastructure to support Mumbai Metropolitan Region's expansion

Noida International Airport (Jewar Airport):

- India's **largest upcoming greenfield airport** serving the Delhi-NCR region.
- **Location:** Jewar, Uttar Pradesh
- **Type:** Greenfield Airport
- **Features:**
 - Phase-1 capacity of 12 million passengers annually.
 - Planned as a major aviation hub with multi-modal connectivity.

Bhogapuram International Airport:

- A greenfield airport project to enhance connectivity in coastal Andhra Pradesh.
- **Location:** Near Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh
- **Type:** Greenfield Airport
- **Features:**
 - Developed by GMR Group for domestic and international operations.
 - Supports tourism and economic growth in [North Coastal Andhra](#).

Dholera International Airport:

- A greenfield airport supporting the [Dholera Special Investment Region \(SIR\)](#).
- **Location:** Gujarat
- **Type:** Greenfield Airport
- **Features:**
 - Integrated with Dholera smart city and industrial corridor.
 - Enhances logistics and manufacturing ecosystem.

Regional Greenfield / Upgraded Airports:

Satna Airport:

- A regional airport under [UDAN scheme](#) improving connectivity.
- **Location:** Madhya Pradesh
- **Type:** Greenfield/Revived Regional Airport
- **Features:**
 - Boosts connectivity to Baghelkhand region.
 - Promotes regional economic development.

Datia Airport:

- A regional connectivity airport under UDAN.
- **Location:** Madhya Pradesh
- **Type:** Greenfield/Revived Regional Airport
- **Features:**

- Enhances access to [Bundelkhand region](#).
- Supports tourism and local trade.

Thoothukudi Airport (New Terminal):

- An upgraded airport with a **new terminal building**.
- **Location:** Tamil Nadu
- **Type:** Brownfield Expansion
- **Features:**
 - Capacity increased from 3 lakh to 20 lakh passengers annually.
 - Modern infrastructure to support [regional aviation](#) growth.

THE BALTIC SEA



- The Baltic Sea is a semi-enclosed, brackish inland sea located in Northern Europe. It is one of the world's largest bodies of [brackish water](#) (a mix of fresh and salt water) and serves as a critical maritime corridor for trade, energy, and telecommunications.
- **Location & Bordering Nations:** The sea is positioned between the Scandinavian Peninsula, the mainland of Northern and Central Europe, and the Danish islands.
- **It is bordered by nine countries:** Denmark, Estonia, Finland, Germany, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, Russia, and Sweden.
- It is connected to the [Atlantic Ocean](#) via the [North Sea](#) through the narrow straits of [Kattegat](#) and [Skagerrak](#).

Key Characteristics:

- **Shallow and Semi-Enclosed:** The Baltic Sea is relatively shallow, with an average depth of about 55 m, and its narrow connection with the North Sea causes very slow water circulation, leading to nearly 30 years for complete water renewal.
- **Brackish Nature:** The mixing of freshwater from 200+ rivers and limited saline inflow from the North Sea creates [brackish water](#), resulting in vertical salinity layering and a highly stratified marine ecosystem.
- **Low Biodiversity, High Sensitivity:** Because of its

young geological formation and unstable salinity conditions, only limited species survive here, making the ecosystem highly fragile and easily disturbed by pollutants or invasive organisms.

- **Anthropogenic Pressure:** Heavy shipping traffic and dense underwater infrastructure such as [Nord Stream pipelines](#), telecom cables, and offshore wind farms increase ecological stress and accident risks in the Baltic region.

LVIV'S HISTORIC ARCHITECTURAL ENSEMBLE



- The Historic Centre of Lviv, Ukraine, preserves a medieval street layout and rich Baroque, Renaissance, and [Neoclassical architecture](#). Largely spared during World War II, it reflects a unique blend of Central and Eastern [European styles](#) with Italian and German influences.
- **Origin:** Founded in the late Middle Ages (mid-13th century) by King Daniel of Galicia.

Part of UNESCO Since:

- The ensemble has been inscribed on the **UNESCO World Heritage List since 1998**.

Characteristics:

- **Multi-Ethnic Layout:** The city was designed with distinct quarters for different ethnic groups (Armenians, Jews, Orthodox Ukrainians, and Catholic Poles), each contributing unique architectural styles.
- **High Density:** A concentrated urban fabric featuring over 2,000 registered landmarks.
- **Stylistic Fusion:** A rare blend of Eastern European traditions and Western European influences (particularly [Italian Renaissance](#) and Austrian Baroque).
- **The Rynok Square:** A central marketplace surrounded by 44 unique townhouses representing various historical periods.

Protection Under International Law:

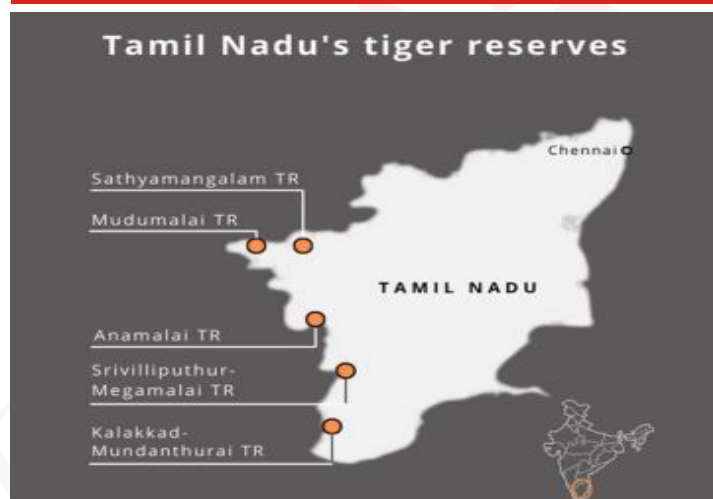
UNESCO sites in war zones are protected under the 1954 [Hague Convention for the Protection of Cultural](#)

Property in the Event of Armed Conflict.

- **The Blue Shield:** Sites are often marked with a distinctive [Blue Shield emblem](#) to indicate they should not be targeted.

INDIA:

MEGAMALAI WILDLIFE SANCTUARY



- Megamalai Wildlife Sanctuary is a protected landscape in Tamil Nadu, often referred to as the High Wavy Mountains. Since 2021, it has been a core component of the [Srivilliputhur–Megamalai Tiger Reserve \(SMTR\)](#), which is India's 51st tiger reserve.

Established In:

- The sanctuary was formally part of the SMTR notification in **2021**, though its Eco-Sensitive Zone was previously gazetted in **2018**.

Habitat:

- The sanctuary is a mosaic of diverse ecosystems, including:
 - Montane Shola Forests and high-altitude grasslands.
 - [Tropical Wet Evergreen](#) Forests.
 - Tea and Cardamom Plantations interspersed with [natural vegetation](#).

Rivers Flowing Through:

The landscape acts as a critical watershed for southern Tamil Nadu. Key rivers include:

- **Vaigai:** The lifeline of several southern districts.
- **Suruliyaru and Shanmuganathi:** Major tributaries that converge at the Vaigai Dam.
- **Ephemeral Streams:** Includes Arjuna Nadhi, Mudangiar, and Gundar, which support local agriculture and drinking water needs.

Key Features:

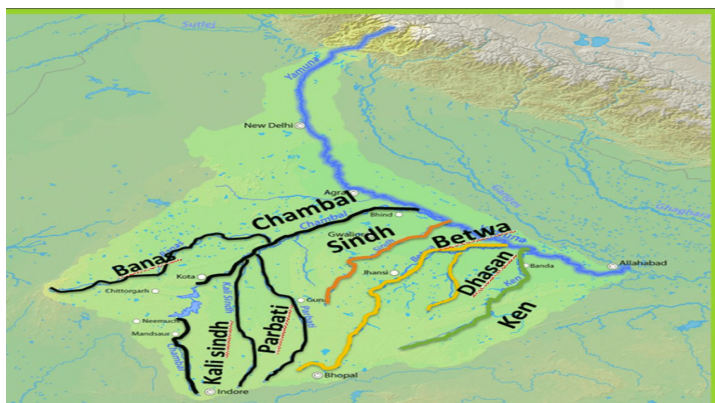
- **Strategic Location:** It forms a continuous elephant and tiger corridor connecting the Periyar Tiger Reserve in Kerala with the [Grizzled Giant Squirrel Sanctuary](#) in Srivilliputhur.
- **Bio-Indicators:** The presence of specific mayflies and amphibians serves as a natural gauge for water quality and habitat stability.
- **Eco-Sensitive Zone (ESZ):** The sanctuary maintains a protective buffer (ESZ) ranging from 0 km to 1.70 km to minimize human-wildlife conflict.

Species Identified:

The ZSI survey documented **977 species**, with the following nine being entirely new to science:

- **Jumping Spider:** *Stenaclurillus megamalai*.
- **Mayflies:** *Edmundsula meghamalaiensis*.
- **Damselfly:** *Thraulius vellimalaiensis* - *Protosticta sholai* (endemic to the region).
- **Bark Lice & Cockroaches:** *Allacta vellimalai* and *Lachesilla vellimalai*.
- **Other Notable Fauna:** Megamalai rock gecko (*Hemidactylus vanam*), and historical records of the Critically Endangered Malabar Civet.

THE CHAMBAL RIVER



- A perennial, rain-fed river in central and northern India, forming a vital part of the greater Gangetic drainage system. The Chambal is one of India's most pristine and ecologically significant rivers, remarkably known for being nearly pollution-free and hosting a rich diversity of rare aquatic fauna.

Origin:

- It rises at Janapav (Singar Chouri peak) in the [Vindhya Range](#), just south of Mhow in the Indore district of Madhya Pradesh, at an elevation of approximately 843 meters.

States Flow Through:

- It flows through three primary states: **Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Uttar Pradesh**.
- It also serves as a natural boundary between Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh.

Tributary:

- It is the chief and largest tributary of the [Yamuna River](#). It joins the Yamuna at Pachnada (near Bhareh, UP) in a unique confluence of five rivers.

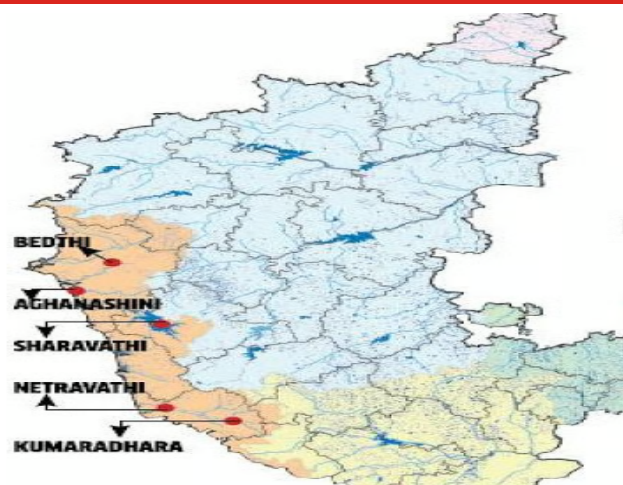
Other Tributaries of Chambal:

- **Left Bank:** Banas (rising in the Aravallis), Mej.
- **Right Bank:** Kali Sindh, Parbati, Shipra, Kuno, Seep, and Kwari.

Key Features of the Chambal River:

1. **Badland Topography:** The lower course is famous for the **Chambal Ravines** (badlands), a 16-km belt of deep gullies caused by accelerated soil erosion.
2. **Ancient Lineage:** Geologically, it is an **anterior-drainage** river, meaning it is much older than the Yamuna and Ganges rivers into which it eventually flows.
3. **Untouched Purity:** Unlike many Indian rivers, it is considered legendary for being **pollution-free**, largely due to local myths that once kept industrial and human activity away from its banks.
4. **Deep Pools:** During the summer or lean seasons, the river forms deep natural pools which become critical refuge points for large [aquatic mammals](#) and reptiles.
5. **Steep Gradient:** In its initial 16-km stretch, the river falls nearly 305 meters, eventually passing through dramatic gorges like the one near Chaurasigarh Fort.

AGHANASHINI-VEDAVATHI RIVER-LINKING PROJECT



About Aghanashini River:

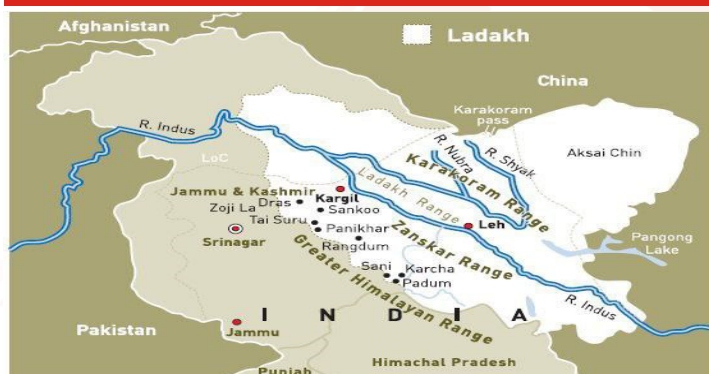
- **What it is?**
 - The Aghanashini is one of the most pristine, free-flowing rivers in India. Unlike most major rivers in the country, it remains largely **undammed** and lacks significant [industrial pollution](#), making it an ecological rarity in the West Coast river system.

- **Origin:**
 - It originates at **Sirsi** (specifically in the 'Shankara Tirtha' of the Heggarne forest range) in the Uttara Kannada district of Karnataka.
- **State Flow Through:**
 - It flows entirely through the state of **Karnataka** before emptying into the Arabian Sea.
 - The Aghanashini is **not a tributary**; it is an independent, west-flowing river that drains directly into the **Arabian Sea** at Tadri in the Kumta taluk.

About Vedavati River:

- **What it is?**
 - The Vedavati is a significant **east-flowing river** in South India. Unlike the Aghanashini, which is a short, west-flowing mountain river, the Vedavati is a long, plateau river that eventually joins the **Bay of Bengal system**. It is a lifeline for the semi-arid regions of central Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh.
- **Origin:**
 - The river is formed by the confluence of two streams, the **Veda** and the **Avati**, which originate in the **Bababudangiri mountain range** of the Western Ghats (Chikkamagaluru district, Karnataka).
 - The two streams flow east and unite at **Pura** to form the Vedavati.
- **Vedavati is a Tributary of:**
 - The Vedavati is a major right-bank tributary of the **Tungabhadra River**.
 - The Tungabhadra itself is the largest tributary of the **Krishna River**. Therefore, the Vedavati is part of the larger **Krishna River Basin**.

ZOJILA PASS



- Zojila is a strategic high mountain pass in the Western Himalayas. Often referred to as the mountain pass of blizzards (though scientifically named after the Tibetan goddess *Du-Zhi-lha-mo*), it serves as the only terrestrial link between the **Kashmir Valley** and the high-altitude cold desert of Ladakh.

Location:

- **Geography:** It is situated at an elevation of

approximately **3,580 metres** (though some sections reach up to 5,008 metres), making it the second-highest pass on the Srinagar–**Leh Highway** after Fotu La.

- **Administrative Boundaries:** It sits on the boundary between the **Ganderbal district** of Jammu and Kashmir and the **Kargil district** of Ladakh.
- **Connectivity:** It connects **Sonmarg** (Kashmir) to the **Dras** and **Suru** valleys, eventually leading to Leh.

History:

- **1948 Indo-Pak War:** The pass was a major battleground during the First Kashmir War. It was initially seized by Gilgit rebels/Pakistan forces in 1948.
- **Operation Bison:** In a historic military feat on November 1, 1948, Indian forces recaptured the pass using tanks. This remains the **highest altitude** at which tanks have ever operated in combat in world history.
- **The Tunnel Era:** To overcome the pass's vulnerability to heavy snowfall and avalanches, the **Zoji-la Tunnel** (14 km long) is currently under construction. Once finished, it will be the longest bidirectional tunnel in Asia.

Key Features:

- **Climatic Extremes:** The pass faces extremely harsh winters with temperatures dropping to -44°C , while **heavy snowfall** (major share of ~ 2600 mm precipitation) disrupts mobility and increases hazard exposure.
- **Geological Sensitivity:** Highly avalanche-prone terrain where even sunlight-induced melting destabilizes snow layers, triggering sudden slides and making travel unpredictable.
- **Zero Point:** A popular high-altitude tourist spot with permanent snow cover, but its heavy footfall combined with fragile terrain makes it vulnerable to disasters.
- **Seasonal Blockages:** Traditionally closed for ~ 6 months due to snow accumulation, though efforts by Border Roads Organisation have improved year-round connectivity.

VEERANGANA DURGAVATI TIGER RESERVE

- It is a massive protected area formed by the notification of the erstwhile **Nauradehi Wildlife Sanctuary** and **Durgavati Wildlife Sanctuary**. It is unique for being a Land of Wolves and is now slated to become the first reserve in India where cheetahs will co-exist with a significant population of tigers

and leopards.

Located In:

- The reserve is spread across three districts in the [Bundelkhand region](#) of Madhya Pradesh: **Sagar, Damoh, and Narsinghpur**.

Established In:

- It was officially notified as a Tiger Reserve in **September 2023**, following the approval of the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA).

Key Features:

- Vast Landscape:** Spanning **2,339 square km**, it offers a massive, contiguous habitat essential for the wide-ranging movements of large carnivores like tigers and cheetahs.
- Savannah-like Terrain:** The topography of the Mohli Range within the reserve closely resembles the **South African veld**, characterized by open grasslands and scrub forests, which is the ideal hunting ground for cheetahs.
- Riverine Ecosystem:** The reserve is intersected by the **Bamner River**, which supports diverse aquatic biodiversity, including rare turtle species like Tera Prince and Sundari.
- High Prey Base:** It maintains a healthy population of chital, sambar, and blackbuck, alongside being a thriving habitat for the [Indian Wolf](#) and over 240 species of birds.

About Project Cheetah:

- Project Cheetah** is the world's first intercontinental large wild carnivore translocation project, aimed at restoring the only large mammal species that went extinct in independent India. The project involves the phased introduction of [African Cheetahs](#) (*Acinonyx jubatus jubatus*) into Indian deciduous forests and grasslands.
- Launched In:** The project was officially launched by **Prime Minister of India on September 17, 2022**.

Designated Reserves:

- As of March 2026, the project has expanded to three designated homes in India (all within Madhya Pradesh)
 - Kuno National Park (Sheopur):** The primary site and current hub of the population.
 - Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary (Mandsaur):** The second site prepared to handle overflow and secondary populations.
 - Veerangana Durgavati Tiger Reserve (Sagar/Damoh/Narsinghpur):** The third home, currently under development for release in mid-2026.

THE PADMA RIVER



- The Padma is the main channel of the **Ganges (Ganga)** river in Bangladesh. It flows southeast for approximately 120 kilometers until it joins the [Meghna River](#) near the Bay of Bengal. It is known for its massive width, shifting channels, and high discharge rates.

Origin:

- The river enters Bangladesh from India near Chapai Nawabganj. It originates where the main branch of the Ganges bifurcates (splits) at the **Farakka Barrage** in the Murshidabad district of West Bengal, India.

Tributaries (Feeding into the Padma):

- The **Mahananda River** is a major tributary that joins the Padma in northwestern Bangladesh.

Distributaries:

- Several important rivers branch off from the Padma, including the **Ariyal Khan, Madhumati**, and the **Bhairab**.
- Major Confluence:** The Padma is a major tributary of the Meghna River system; the two join at Chandpur before flowing into the sea.

Key Geological Features:

- Braided Character:** The Padma is a classic **braided river**, characterized by multiple shifting channels and chars (temporary sandy islands) created by high sediment loads.
- High Erosion Rate:** It is notorious for its bank erosion, which frequently displaces coastal communities and alters the geography of the surrounding districts.
- Massive Discharge:** During the [monsoon season](#), the Padma carries a staggering volume of water, often exceeding **75,000 cubic meters per second**.
- The Padma Bridge:** A feat of modern engineering, the 6.15 km multipurpose bridge spans the river, connecting the southwest of the country to the capital, Dhaka.